

“Well, no,” Penny admitted. “It sounded sensible. There wasn’t anything wrong with doing that, was there?”

“Not the purchase itself, if you had had the money to spare, no.” Penny shifted uncomfortably in her seat. “But there are other sources of advice on financial matters.”

“Such as—?” Penny prompted him.

“Well, primarily after Scripture, I look at what Christian experts have to say,” Natalie offered. “They not only seek and give godly counsel, but they have your best interests in mind.”

“Another good source is the good old-fashioned newspaper,” Tim added. “I’ve found that the more I read by mainstream, respected columnists, the greater discernment I develop to, well, to smell a rat ... or at least to nose out advice that doesn’t stand up to God’s truth.”

Penny was starting to feel overwhelmed, as though there was no way out of her situation. When she said so, Natalie and Tim both assured her that it was God’s desire to bring her out of debt and that there were people who would help her do so.

The Brookers set Penny up with a Christian credit counseling service similar to the one Beth had gone to. With their help, she learned to set up and live within a budget, to save for purchases and emergencies, and to discipline herself from using her charge cards. They worked with her creditors to get the interest rates down to amounts that could actually be paid off, and, through hard work that she looked at as an adventure—and a few stumbles—Penny was debt-free within five years.

The best part of her new life, of course, wasn’t just being free of the weight of debt—but was the freedom of walking with Christ, of finding the joy of giving, and of experiencing His provision.